Board Policy 2.20.010-P

Naming School District Property

I. Responsibility and Authority

A. The naming of all Portland Public Schools properties including, but not limited to, schools, school facilities, programs, non-school facilities, as well as school mascots, symbols and other images considered for representation of a school or PPS. is the responsibility of the Board of Education.

B. In considering appropriate names for any school, facility, programs, or representative images, it is the responsibility of the Board to ensure that the name properly reflects the type and mission of the school, facility, and focus option so as to not cause public confusion. In respect for the diversity of our community, names will have broad acceptance in a multicultural society as determined by the Board.

C. In the naming process, the Board recognizes the importance of soliciting student, staff, parent and community input, as appropriate, in the selection of names. Names may be presented by individuals, by petition, by chosen committees, or by other representative groups. While efforts will be made to respect student, staff, parent, and community preferences, the Board retains the final authority over selection of names for schools, facilities, programs and representative images.

D. Requests for renaming of PPS properties may be presented by individuals, by petition, by chosen committees, or by other representative groups to the Board. The petition needs to demonstrate diverse school community support or indicate the name change is being requested in accordance with section II (A) in this policy.

E. The Board will take one of these actions:

i. Direct the Superintendent to conduct a renaming process;

ii. Decline the request; or

iii. Defer action on the request to a later date.

F. If the Board directs the Superintendent to conduct a renaming process, the Superintendent will note the staff or financial resources needed to conduct the process.

II. General Criteria for Names

When evaluating school, non-school facility, program names, and representative images, the following general criteria will be followed:

A. Names submitted for consideration may:

i. be known and significant to the community, students and staff;

ii. relate to local neighborhoods, to relevant geographic areas; to places of historical, geographical, geologic or cultural significance; to indigenous and characteristic flora or fauna;

iii. be persons or groups of persons, deceased at least three years, who have demonstrated international, national, state or local leadership in the fields of education, arts and sciences, or public service; or be thematic to reflect the character of the community culture and history; or

iv. reflect features of the facility or program type and the mission of the facility.

v. All considerations must reflect our commitment to eliminating racism and other systemic discrimination based on protected classes and its impact on student learning and educational activities.

B. Names submitted for consideration will not:

i. conflict with the names of other schools or programs in PPS or surrounding school districts;

ii. reflect the names of specific cities with the exception of Portland;

iii. be a person, location or character whose primary identification is of a religious nature or be a name of a religious group or members;

iv. include the word 'neighborhood' in the school name unless the school has defined attendance barriers; or

v. include the word 'school' in its name if it is a special program that does not meet the definition of a school as stated in Board Policy 6.10.022-P.

III. Special Recognition of Specific Persons

A. The Board acknowledges that communities served by PPS facilities periodically desire to recognize individuals for long and honorable service. Locations within school facilities or buildings may be named for former PPS employees, citizens or students (not necessarily deceased) who have made specific contributions to education within PPS.

B. Naming of locations inside schools and school facilities are subject to the approval of the Superintendent, with notice to the Board of the naming and the reasons for the recognition.

IV. Gifts

The Board acknowledges that it has the authority to accept monetary or in-kind donations from individuals and entities. In exceptional circumstances, consideration may be given to naming locations within a school or non-school facility for a significant gift as determined by the Board, in consultation with the Superintendent. Any names in this instance will be consistent with all Board policies and will reflect the donor's appropriate financial support as well as the donor commitment to PPS's mission and vision and the objectives of the public school system.

V. Charter Schools

Agreements signed between public charter schools and PPS will contain the requirement that the word 'Charter' be included as part of the charter school name. Charter schools do not have defined attendance boundaries and, thus, will not have the title 'neighborhood' as part of their name.

VI. School Conversions, Mergers, or Reconfigurations

When a school undergoes conversion or is reconfigured into separate distinct units, each of which meets the definition of a school as stated in Board Policy 6.10.022-P, those schools will be named following the conditions and criteria for new schools as outlined in this policy. When two or more schools are merged and there is community support for a name other than the current name of the facility, the school community will go through the renaming process using the criteria in this policy. PPS will waive the fiscal impact statement in these cases.

VII. Renaming or Amending of Current Names

A. The Board recognizes that renaming existing schools or facilities or amending existing names by adding or deleting words or phrases is a serious, considered decision, and should not be made arbitrarily, frivolously, or in haste.

B. Such a decision must take into account PPS's focus on eliminating racism and other systemic discrimination based on protected classes and its impact on student learning and educational activities.

C. Because the impact of renaming an existing school or amending an existing name is substantial in terms of potential public confusion, and administrative and fiscal costs, the burden is upon the party or parties proposing the name change to present persuasive evidence that the benefits of renaming outweigh community and PPS impacts.

D. Central PPS staff will provide significant support to school-based administrators during a renaming process.

E. In considering a name change, the Board will consider input and recommendations from the school community and the community at large. The request for a name change must be accompanied by a fiscal impact statement and a proposed method of covering the expense of the name change.

    i. PPS will allow for an exemption to the fiscal impact statement and proposed method of covering the expense of the name change when a party can show the change is being made to address discrimination.

VIII. Implementation

A. The Board has the ultimate authority to determine if the criteria in this policy have been satisfied.

B. The Board authorizes the Superintendent to develop procedures which provide for implementation of this policy.

History: Adopted 7/12/2004; Amended 4/2018, 12/2023, _____